USCG CAPTAIN'S LICENSE · OUPV / MASTER

Rules of the Road

Visual study guide — diagrams, memory hooks & exam traps



Covers International (COLREGS 72) and U.S. Inland Rules side by side
Rules 1–38 · Lights · Day shapes · Sound signals · Fog · Distress
Prepared for Jesse Orebaugh · October 2026

How this exam module works

Rules of the Road (ROR) passes at **90%** (so does Chart Plotting); Deck General and Nav General pass at 70%. Every question is tagged with the rule set it applies to — **BOTH International & Inland**, **INTERNATIONAL ONLY**, or **INLAND ONLY**. Most questions are 'Both,' so learn the shared rules cold, then memorize the short list of differences on the Inland vs. International page.

- **Read the tag first.** The same signal can mean two different things (e.g., two short blasts). Decide which book you're in before reading the stem.
- **Read the last sentence first.** Long scenario stems often bury the actual question at the end.
- **Shall vs. may.** Many distractors swap a mandatory action for a permitted one — the rules are precise about which is which.
- **'Day' vs 'night' vs 'restricted visibility'.** Shapes are day, lights are night (and in restricted visibility by day), sound signals are for when vessels are in sight (maneuvering) or not (fog).
- Verify the current exam format with your school or REC — question counts and module splits change periodically.

The book at a glance

Part	Rules	What it covers	Hook
A — General	1–3	Application, Responsibility, Definitions	**A**pply
B — Steering & Sailing	4–19	Sect. I: any visibility (4–10) · Sect. II: in sight (11–18) · Sect. III: restricted visibility (19)	**B**ehave
C — Lights & Shapes	20–31	Arcs, ranges, what each vessel shows	**C**an you see me?
D — Sound & Light Signals	32–37	Equipment, maneuvering, fog, attention, distress	**D**o you hear me?
E — Exemptions	38	Grandfathered older vessels	**E**xcused
Annexes	I–V	I: positioning/technical · II: fishing in close proximity · III: sound appliances · IV: distress · V: pilot rules (Inland)	

MEMORY HOOK **A-B-C-D-E**

Apply → **B**ehave → **C**an you *see* me? → **D**o you *hear* me? → **E**xcused. If a question is about what you *see*, it's Part C; what you *hear*, Part D; what you *do*, Part B.

Rules 1–2: Application and Responsibility

- **Rule 1:** International Rules apply on the high seas and connected waters navigable by seagoing vessels. Inland Rules apply **shoreward of the COLREGS Demarcation Lines** (33 CFR 80), including the Great Lakes and Western Rivers.
- **Rule 2 (the 'General Prudential Rule'):** Nothing exonerates the owner, master, or crew from neglecting any precaution required by the ordinary practice of seamen. You **may depart** from the rules when necessary to avoid immediate danger.

EXAM TRAP **Rule 2 is the escape hatch — but only for immediate danger**

If an answer choice says you may disregard the rules 'for convenience' or 'to save time,' it's wrong. Departure is allowed only to avoid immediate danger, and you're still responsible.

Rule 3: Definitions that get tested

Term	Meaning — and the trick
Vessel	Every watercraft used or capable of being used for transport on water, including non-displacement craft, WIG craft, and seaplanes.

Term	Meaning — and the trick
Power-driven	Any vessel propelled by machinery. **A sailboat with its engine running is power-driven** (even with sails up).
Sailing vessel	Under sail, provided propelling machinery, if fitted, is **not being used**.
Engaged in fishing	Nets, lines, trawls or other gear that **restricts maneuverability**. **Trolling lines do NOT count.**
NUC (Not Under Command)	Through some **exceptional circumstance** is unable to maneuver as required (e.g., steering or engine failure).
RAM (Restricted in Ability to Maneuver)	From the **nature of her work** is restricted: buoy tending, dredging, surveying, diving/underwater ops, replenishment underway, launching/recovering aircraft, mine clearance, towing that severely restricts deviation.
CBD (Constrained by Draft) — Intl only	Power-driven vessel severely restricted by her draft relative to available depth and width of navigable water.
Underway	Not at anchor, not made fast to shore, not aground. **Drifting with engines stopped is still underway.**
Length / breadth	Length overall / greatest breadth.
In sight	Only when one can be **observed visually** from the other. Radar contact is NOT 'in sight.'
Restricted visibility	Visibility restricted by fog, mist, falling snow, heavy rainstorms, sandstorms, or similar causes.

MEMORY HOOK **NUC vs RAM**

NUC = No Usable Control — something *broke* (accident). **RAM = Restricted by Assigned Mission** — it's *working* (by choice). If the question mentions the job the vessel is doing → RAM. If it mentions a failure → NUC.

Rule 18: Who gives way to whom

When vessels are **in sight** of one another, a vessel keeps out of the way of anything *higher* on this ladder. NUC and RAM share the top rung — neither has priority over the other under Rule 18.



MEMORY HOOK **Never Rile Cranky Fishermen, Sailors, or Powerboaters**

NUC · **R**AM · **C**BD · **F**ishing · **S**ailing · **P**ower. Read top-down: each one gets out of the way of everyone in front of it in the sentence.

EXAM TRAP Rule 18 has exceptions that beat the ladder

- **Rule 13 (Overtaking) wins every time.** A sailboat overtaking a power-driven vessel must keep clear — the ladder doesn't help an overtaker.
- **Rule 9 (Narrow channels) and Rule 10 (Traffic separation):** vessels under 20 m, sailing vessels, and fishing vessels **shall not impede** a vessel that can safely navigate only within the channel or lane.
- Rule 18 is a 'Section II' rule — it applies **only in sight**. In fog (Rule 19) there is no stand-on or give-way vessel.

Rules 5–8: Conduct in any visibility

Rule	Key requirement	Remember it
5 Look-out	Proper look-out by **sight and hearing** and all available means.	Eyes, ears, radar — at all times.
6 Safe speed	Speed that lets you take proper and effective action and **stop within an appropriate distance**. Factors for all vessels: visibility, traffic density, maneuverability (stopping distance, turning), background lights at night, wind/sea/current/hazards, draft vs. depth. Radar vessels add: radar limits, range scale, sea state and weather clutter, small targets not detected.	**V**ery **T**ired **M**ariners **B**ring **W**et **D**ogs: **V**isibility, **T**raffic, **M**aneuverability, **B**ackground light, **W**ind/sea/current, **D**raft
7 Risk of collision	Risk exists if the **compass bearing does not appreciably change**. Can still exist with a changing bearing — very large vessel, a tow, or at close range. Don't assume on scanty (especially scanty radar) information. If in doubt, risk exists.	**CBDR** = Constant Bearing, Decreasing Range = collision course.
8 Action to avoid	Positive, in ample time, **large enough to be readily apparent** visually or by radar. **Avoid a succession of small alterations.** Slacken speed or take all way off if needed.	Make it BIG, make it EARLY, make it OBVIOUS.

Rules 9–10: Narrow channels and Traffic Separation Schemes

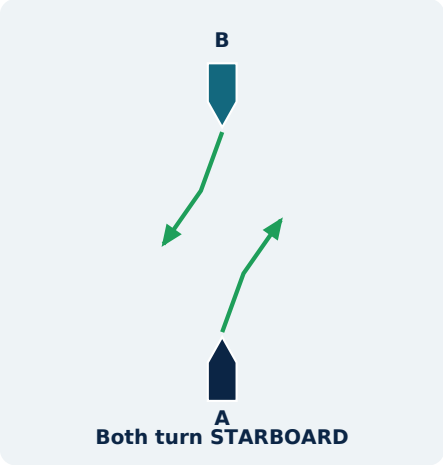
- **Keep to starboard** side of a narrow channel or fairway, as near the outer limit as safe and practicable.
- Vessels **< 20 m** and **sailing vessels** shall not impede a vessel that can safely navigate only within the channel. **Fishing vessels** shall not impede any other vessel navigating within it.
- Don't **cross** a channel if it impedes a vessel confined to it. If that vessel is in doubt about the crossing vessel's intentions: International — she **MAY** sound the danger signal; **Inland — she SHALL** sound it (Rule 9(d)).
- Approaching a **bend** where other vessels may be obscured: one **prolonged** blast (answered by one prolonged). Avoid anchoring in a narrow channel.
- **TSS:** proceed in the appropriate lane in its general direction of traffic; join/leave at the ends or at as small an angle as practicable; if you must cross a lane, do so on a **heading** as nearly as practicable at **right angles** to the general direction of traffic.

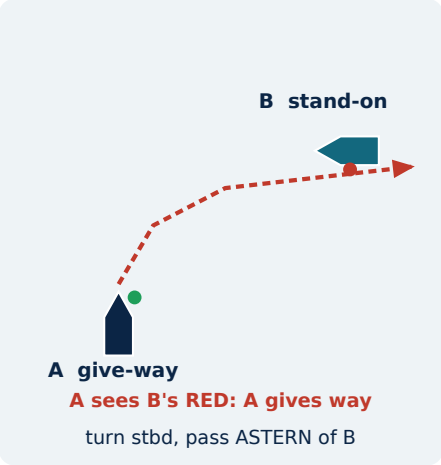
INLAND ≠ INTERNATIONAL Inland Rule 9 — Western Rivers & Great Lakes

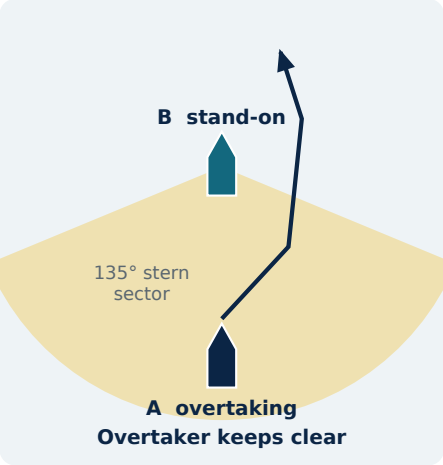
On the Great Lakes, Western Rivers, and other specified waters, a power-driven vessel **proceeding downbound with a following current has the right-of-way** over an upbound vessel, **proposes the manner and place of passage**, and initiates the maneuvering signals. Reason: the downbound boat has less control with the current pushing it. *Hook:* '*Down with the flow, she runs the show.*'

Rules 13–17: The three power-driven encounters

These apply only to vessels **in sight** of each other. Identify which situation you're in first; the action follows automatically.







Left to right: Head-on (Rule 14) · Crossing (Rule 15) · Overtaking (Rule 13)

Situation	How you know	Who acts	What they do
Overtaking (13)	Coming up from **more than 22.5° abaft the beam** of the other — at night you'd see **only her sternlight**, no sidelights. If in doubt, assume you're overtaking.	The overtaking vessel (any type!)	Keep out of the way until **finally past and clear**. A later change in bearing never makes the overtaker a crossing vessel.
Head-on (14)	Reciprocal or nearly reciprocal courses. At night: masthead lights in line and/or **both sidelights** visible. By day: other vessel's masts in line. If in doubt, assume head-on.	**Both** vessels	Each alters course to **starboard** → pass **port-to-port**.
Crossing (15)	Neither of the above. The vessel that has the other on her own **starboard side** is the give-way vessel.	Give-way vessel	Keep out of the way; if circumstances admit, **avoid crossing ahead** of the other (usually turn to stbd and pass astern).

MEMORY HOOK **Traffic-light logic for crossings**
If you see the other vessel's **RED** sidelight → **STOP**: you are the give-way vessel. If you see her **GREEN** → **GO**: you stand on. And: '*Danger zone*' = *from dead ahead to 22.5° abaft your starboard beam* — anything crossing in your green sector is your problem.

Rule 16 & 17: Give-way and stand-on duties

The give-way vessel takes **early and substantial** action. The stand-on vessel goes through four stages as the range closes:

1 No risk yet
Either vessel free to maneuver

2 Risk exists
Stand-on SHALL keep course & speed

3 Give-way not acting
Stand-on MAY act (sound 5+ short first)

4 Collision imminent
Stand-on SHALL take best action to avoid

far apart → close quarters

EXAM TRAP Rule 17(c) — the 'don't turn left' rule

When a power-driven **stand-on** vessel does take action in a **crossing** situation, she shall, if circumstances admit, **not alter course to port for a vessel on her own port side** — because that vessel is likely turning to starboard, straight into you. Also: the stand-on vessel acting does **not** relieve the give-way vessel of her obligation.

Rule 12: Sailing vessels meeting each other





- **Different tacks:** the vessel with the wind on her **port** side keeps out of the way.
- **Same tack:** the **windward** vessel keeps out of the way of the leeward vessel.
- **Port tack and can't tell** whether the other vessel (to windward) is on port or starboard tack → keep out of the way.
- **Windward side** is defined as the side **opposite** the one on which the mainsail is carried (square-rigged: opposite the largest fore-and-aft sail).

MEMORY HOOK Port gives, windward gives

"**P**ort **P**ays" — port tack pays the way. And the windward boat is 'upwind' with more options, so she yields. Quick tack check: the tack is named for the side the wind comes *over*; the boom is always on the opposite side. Boom out to starboard = port tack.

EXAM TRAP Sailing rules apply only between two sailing vessels

Rule 12 doesn't apply if one vessel is motorsailing (she's power-driven), fishing, NUC, RAM, or **overtaking** (Rule 13 still wins).

Rule 19: Conduct in restricted visibility

Applies to vessels **not in sight** of one another in or near an area of restricted visibility. **There is no stand-on or give-way vessel** — everybody is responsible.

- Proceed at a **safe speed**; power-driven vessels have engines **ready for immediate maneuver**.
- If you detect another vessel **by radar alone** and a close-quarters situation is developing, take avoiding action in ample time, but avoid:

Where the other vessel is	AVOID this alteration
Forward of the beam (other than a vessel you are overtaking)	An alteration of course to **PORT**
Abeam or abaft the beam	An alteration of course **TOWARD** the vessel

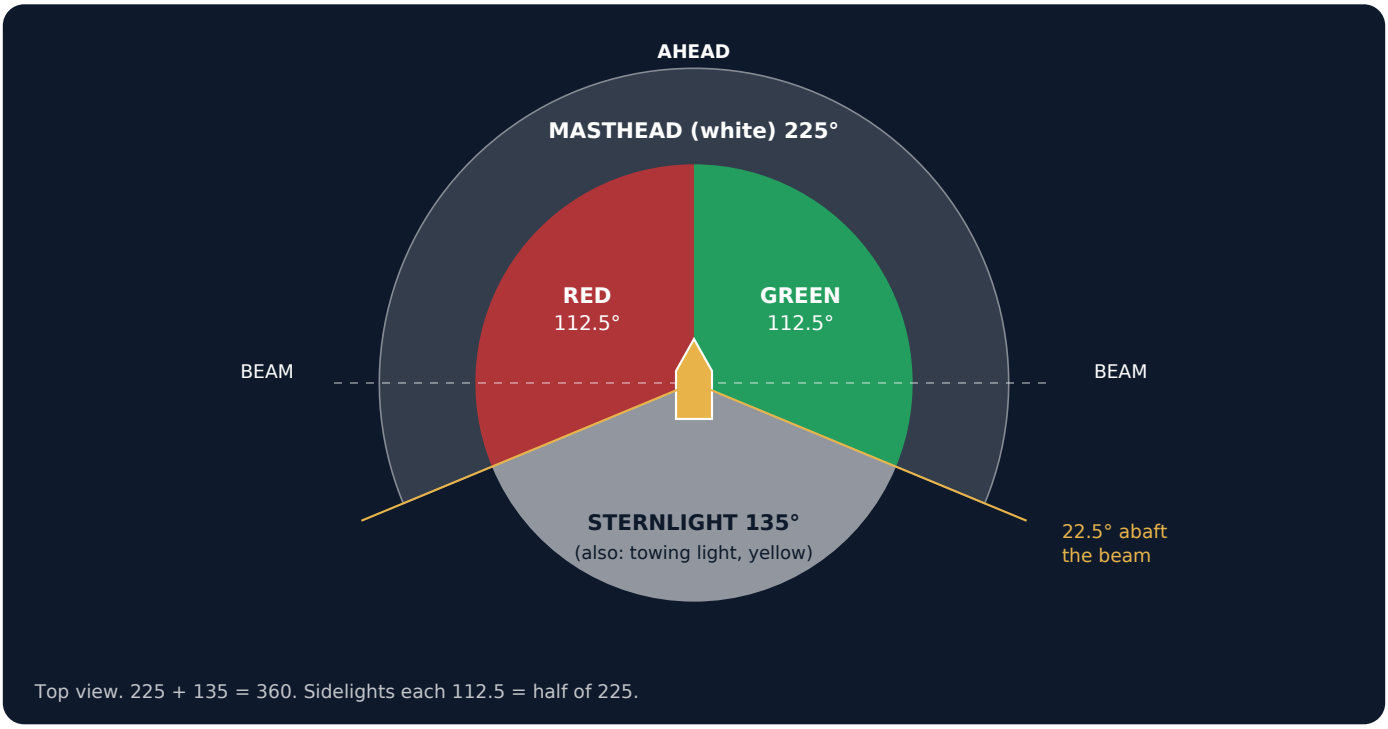
- If you **hear a fog signal apparently forward of your beam**, or can't avoid a close-quarters situation with a vessel forward of the beam: reduce speed to the **minimum to keep steerage**, take all way off if

necessary, and navigate with extreme caution until the danger is over.

MEMORY HOOK "In fog, starboard is your friend; never turn toward a ghost."
Ahead → don't go left. Beside or behind → don't go toward it. Hear something ahead → slow to bare steerageway.

Part C: Lights — arcs and ranges

Lights are shown **sunset to sunrise** and in restricted visibility by day. Shapes are shown **by day**. Know the arcs cold — almost every lights question is solved by asking 'which arcs could I see from where I am?'



Top view. 225 + 135 = 360. Sidelights each 112.5 = half of 225.

Light	Arc	≥ 50 m	12–50 m	< 12 m
Masthead (white)	225°	6 nm	5 nm (3 nm if < 20 m)	2 nm
Sidelights (red/green)	112.5° each	3 nm	2 nm	1 nm
Sternlight (white)	135°	3 nm	2 nm	2 nm
Towing light (yellow)	135°	3 nm	2 nm	2 nm
All-round (any color)	360°	3 nm	2 nm	2 nm

MEMORY HOOK "6-3-3 / 5-2-2 / 2-1-2"
Masthead–side–stern for big (≥50 m), medium (12–50 m), small (<12 m). Masthead is always the farthest-reaching light. The only time sidelights drop to **1 nm** is on vessels under 12 m. Everything else (stern, towing, all-round) follows the sternlight.

Power-driven vessels underway (Rule 23)

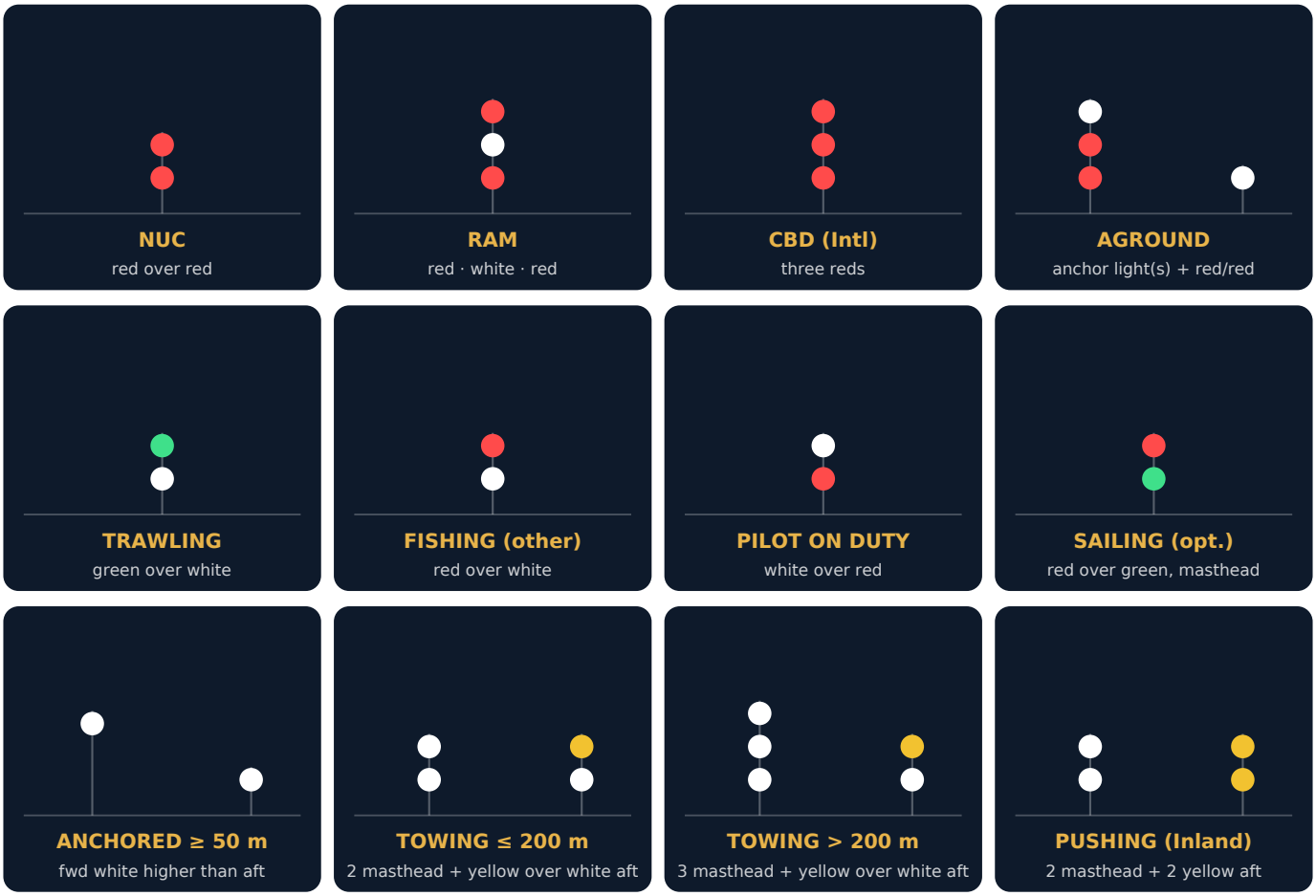
- Masthead light forward; a **second masthead light abaft and higher** than the forward one if **≥ 50 m** (optional if shorter); sidelights; sternlight.
- **< 12 m:** may show an all-round white light + sidelights instead.
- **International:** < 7 m with max speed ≤ 7 knots may show just an all-round white light (and sidelights if practicable).

- **Air-cushion** vessel in non-displacement mode adds an **all-round flashing yellow**. WIG craft in ground effect adds a **high-intensity all-round flashing red**.

INLAND ≠ INTERNATIONAL Great Lakes
On the Great Lakes a power-driven vessel may carry an **all-round white light** in lieu of the second masthead light and sternlight.

Light recognition — what you'll see at night

Profile views of the **distinctive** lights only (all-round unless noted). When the vessel is **making way**, add sidelights + sternlight (and masthead lights for RAM, CBD, and power-driven types).



Rhyme	Means
Red over red, the captain is dead	NUC — two all-round red
Red, white, red — work ahead (or: 'RAM sandwich: white bread inside red')	RAM — red/white/red. Add masthead+sides+stern when making way; add anchor lights at anchor
Three reds in a row — too deep to go	CBD — Intl only (shape: cylinder, a 'can' of deep water)
Green over white, trawling tonight	Trawling (dragging a net)
Red over white, fishing at night	Fishing other than trawling. Gear out >150 m horizontally: add all-round white toward the gear
White over red, pilot ahead ('white cap, red nose')	Pilot vessel on duty
Red over green, sailing machine	Optional sailing lights at masthead — never combined with a tricolor

Rhyme	Means
Yellow over white, towing tonight	Towing astern: towing light above the sternlight
Yellow over yellow, pushing, fellow	Inland: pushing ahead / towing alongside shows two towing lights instead of a sternlight

TIP How to count masthead lights on a towing vessel
Two masthead lights in a **vertical line** = towing (or pushing). Three = tow length over 200 m (measured from the stern of the towing vessel to the after end of the tow). Two masthead lights **fore and aft** (aft one higher) = just a power-driven vessel ≥ 50 m.

Lights by vessel type — the details that get tested

Vessel	Lights (night)	Shape (day)
Towing astern (24)	2 masthead in vertical line (3 if tow > 200 m); sidelights; sternlight; **towing light (yellow) above sternlight**	Diamond, only if tow > 200 m
Vessel being towed	Sidelights + sternlight (no masthead)	Diamond if tow > 200 m
Pushing ahead / alongside — Intl	2 masthead in vertical line; sidelights; sternlight	—
Pushing ahead / alongside — Inland	2 masthead in vertical line; sidelights; **two towing lights in vertical line** (instead of sternlight)	—
Western Rivers pushing ahead / alongside	Sidelights + two towing lights; **no masthead lights required** (above the Huey P. Long Bridge on the Mississippi)	—
Vessel pushed ahead — Inland	Sidelights at forward end + **special flashing light** (yellow, 50–70 flashes/min, 180°–225° arc) at forward end	—
Composite unit (rigidly connected pusher/barge)	Lighted as **one power-driven vessel**	—
Sailing underway (25)	Sidelights + sternlight; < 20 m may combine in a **tricolor** at masthead; optional red-over-green all-round at masthead	Motorsailing: **cone, apex down**
Sailing < 7 m / rowing	Sailing lights if practicable; otherwise an electric torch or lantern ready to show in time	—
Trawling (26)	Green over white; masthead light abaft & higher if ≥ 50 m; making way: + sides & stern	Two cones **apexes together** (hourglass); < 20 m may use a basket
Fishing, not trawling	Red over white; gear > 150 m: all-round white toward gear; making way: + sides & stern	Hourglass; gear > 150 m: **cone apex up** toward gear
NUC (27a)	2 all-round red; making way: + sides & stern	2 balls
RAM (27b)	Red-white-red; making way: + masthead(s), sides, stern; at anchor: + anchor lights	Ball-diamond-ball
Dredging / underwater ops with obstruction	RAM lights + **2 red on obstructed side**, **2 green on side to pass**	RAM shapes + 2 balls (obstructed) / 2 diamonds (pass)
Small dive boat	RAM lights	Rigid replica of **code flag 'A'** ≥ 1 m high

Vessel	Lights (night)	Shape (day)
Mine clearance	3 all-round green (masthead + each foreyard end) — stay **1,000 m** clear	3 balls, same layout
CBD (28) — Intl only	Power-driven lights + 3 all-round red in vertical line	Cylinder
Pilot on duty (29)	White over red at masthead; underway + sides & stern; at anchor + anchor lights	—
Anchored (30)	All-round white forward + lower all-round white aft if ≥ 50 m; one light if < 50 m; **≥ 100 m must also light her decks**	1 ball, forward
Aground	Anchor lights + 2 all-round red in vertical line	3 balls in vertical line

TIP Size exemptions worth memorizing

< 7 m at anchor, not in/near a channel, anchorage, or where vessels normally navigate: no anchor lights/shape required. < 12 m aground: no aground lights/shapes required. < 12 m (except divers) need not show NUC/RAM lights. **Inland:** < 20 m at anchor in a designated **special anchorage area** needs no anchor lights or shape.

Day shapes

Four building blocks: **ball**, **cone**, **diamond**, **cylinder**. Shapes are black, displayed where best seen, and almost always mirror the vessel's distinctive lights.



ANCHORED
1 ball forward



NUC
2 balls



AGROUND
3 balls



RAM
ball · diamond · ball



CBD (Intl)
cylinder



FISHING
cones apex together



MOTORSAILING
cone apex down



TOW > 200 m
diamond (both vessels)



GEAR > 150 m
cone apex up, toward gear



DREDGE
+ 2 balls obstructed / 2 diamonds pass



MINE CLEARANCE
3 balls: masthead + yardarms

MEMORY HOOK **Shapes tell a story**

Balls = 'stuck' or 'stopped': 1 ball anchored, 2 balls NUC, 3 balls aground (count up as things get worse). **Diamond** = 'a long string behind me' (tow > 200 m) or the middle of the RAM sandwich. **Hourglass** = fishing — 'time to fish.' **Cone down** = motorsailing — 'my engine pulls the sail *down* to power-driven status.' **Cylinder** = a can of deep water you need (CBD).

EXAM TRAP **Lights vs. shapes mismatches**

Dredge 'pass' side = **green lights by night, diamonds by day**; obstructed side = **red lights, balls**. Pilot vessels have **no** required day shape. A vessel towing < 200 m shows **no** diamond.

Part D: Sound signals

Short blast ≈ 1 second. **Prolonged blast** = 4 to 6 seconds. In the diagrams below: short ▬, prolonged ▬▬▬, bell ▌.

Vessel length	Required sound equipment (Rule 33)
< 12 m	Not required to carry whistle/bell, but must have **some means of making an efficient sound signal**
12 m to < 20 m	Whistle
20 m to < 100 m	Whistle + bell
≥ 100 m	Whistle + bell + gong (gong tone can't be confused with the bell)

Maneuvering & warning signals — vessels IN SIGHT (Rule 34)

Signal		INTERNATIONAL — 'I AM doing'	INLAND — 'I INTEND' (needs reply)
1 short	●	I am altering course to **starboard**	I intend to leave you on my **port** side (port-to-port); overtaking: I intend to pass on your **starboard** side
2 short	● ●	I am altering course to **port**	I intend to leave you on my **starboard** side (stbd-to-stbd); overtaking: I intend to pass on your **port** side
3 short	● ● ●	I am operating astern propulsion	I am operating astern propulsion
5+ short	● ● ● ● ●	Doubt / danger signal	Doubt / danger signal (also the reply when you disagree)
1 prolonged	▬	Approaching a bend / obscured area (answered with 1 prolonged)	Same; **also leaving a dock or berth**
2 prolonged + 1 short	▬ ▬ ●	In narrow channel: I intend to overtake on your **starboard** side	(Inland uses 1 short)
2 prolonged + 2 short	▬ ▬ ● ●	In narrow channel: I intend to overtake on your **port** side	(Inland uses 2 short)
P-S-P-S	▬ ● ▬ ●	Overtaken vessel **agrees** (Morse 'C' = Concur)	Agrees by repeating the same signal

MEMORY HOOK **One = starboard turn = port-to-port. Two = port turn = starboard-to-starboard.**

The number of blasts matches the side you'll be on *after*: 1 short → I go right → we pass **port-to-port** (most common, 'normal' passing). **International = action** ('I AM altering' — no reply required). **Inland = intention** ('I INTEND' — the other vessel must answer with the same signal, or sound danger).

INLAND ≠ INTERNATIONAL Inland details

Inland signals are required when meeting or crossing **within ½ mile**. The light signal may be **white or yellow** (Intl: white only). If agreement is reached by **VHF radiotelephone**, the whistle signals aren't required (but may be sounded). International overtaking signals are used only in a **narrow channel** where the overtaken vessel must act to permit passing.

Restricted visibility sound signals (Rule 35)

Underway signals are sounded at intervals of **not more than 2 minutes**. Anchored/aground signals: **not more than 1 minute**.

Situation	Signal	Pattern / interval
Power-driven, **making way**		1 prolonged · every 2 min
Power-driven, underway but **stopped**		2 prolonged (~2 s apart) · every 2 min
NUC, RAM, CBD, sailing, fishing, towing or pushing — **also** fishing at anchor & RAM at anchor		1 prolonged + 2 short · every 2 min
Towed vessel (last one, if manned)		1 prolonged + 3 short, right after the tug's signal
Anchored		Rapid ringing of bell ~5 s · every 1 min
Anchored, ≥ 100 m		Bell forward, then **gong aft** ~5 s · every 1 min
Anchored — optional warning		1 short + 1 prolonged + 1 short (Morse 'R')
Aground		3 distinct bell strokes + rapid ringing + 3 strokes (gong too if ≥ 100 m)
Pilot vessel on duty (optional)		4 short identity signal (Morse 'H' = Harbor pilot)
< 12 m		Not required to give these, but must make some efficient sound signal every 2 min
< 20 m		Not required to give the bell or gong signals (but must give another efficient signal)

MEMORY HOOK Count the prolongeds — then it's Morse code

1 prolonged = 'I'm moving.' 2 prolonged = 'I'm stopped.' Think '*one = run, two = through (done moving).*'
— • • = Morse **D** = '**D**ifferent / **D**isabled' — every 'special' vessel (NUC, RAM, CBD, sail, fish, tow).
— • • • = Morse **B** = '**B**ehind' — the vessel being towed behind.
• **—** • = Morse **R** = '**R**ight here!' — anchored vessel warning an approaching ship.
• • • • = Morse **H** = '**H**arbor pilot.'
Bell = anchored; three dings bracketing the bell = aground ('ding-ding-ding: I hit something').

EXAM TRAP Sailing vessels don't sound one prolonged

A sailing vessel underway in fog sounds **1 prolonged + 2 short** (not the power-driven 1 prolonged). The moment she starts her engine, she's power-driven: 1 prolonged.

Rule 36 & 37: Attention and distress

Attention signal (36): any light or sound signal that can't be mistaken for a rule signal, or a searchlight aimed so as not to embarrass another vessel. International: avoid high-intensity intermittent or revolving lights (strobes).

Distress signals (Annex IV) — used together or separately:

Sound / radio	Visual
Gun or explosive signal fired at ~1-minute intervals	Rockets or shells throwing **red stars**, fired one at a time at short intervals
Continuous sounding of any fog-signal apparatus	Red parachute flare or red hand flare
SOS (• • • — — — • • •) by any signaling method	Orange smoke signal
Spoken 'MAYDAY' by radiotelephone	Slowly and repeatedly raising and lowering arms outstretched to each side
DSC distress alert; EPIRB signals; approved radio signals	Flames on the vessel (tar barrel, oil barrel)
	International code flags **N over C**; a square flag with a ball (or ball-like object) above or below it
	Orange-colored canvas with a black square and circle; dye marker
	Inland only: high-intensity **white light flashing 50–70 times per minute**

MEMORY HOOK **"No Chance" = N over C**
And 'square and circle' (flag + ball) = 'I'm boxed in, help.' Continuous fog horn = distress; the same horn in a pattern = a normal fog signal.

Inland vs. International — the complete short list

Everything not on this page is the same in both rule sets. These differences produce most 'INLAND ONLY' and 'INTERNATIONAL ONLY' questions.

Topic	International	Inland
Maneuvering signals (34)	Signals of **action** ('I am altering'); no reply needed; when **in sight**	Signals of **intent** ('I intend to leave you on my…'); must be **answered**; within **½ mile**
Overtaking signals	Narrow channel only: 2 prolonged + 1 or 2 short; agree with P-S-P-S	1 short (pass your starboard side) / 2 short (pass your port side); agree by repeating
Doubt about a vessel crossing a narrow channel (9d)	Vessel in the channel **may** sound the danger signal	Vessel in the channel **shall** sound the danger signal
Maneuvering light	White, all-round	White **or yellow**, all-round, synchronized with whistle
Leaving a berth	No specific signal	**1 prolonged** blast
VHF agreement	Doesn't replace whistle	Agreement by radio → whistle signals not required
Constrained by draft	Exists (Rule 28): 3 red / cylinder	**Does not exist**
Downbound with following current	—	Has right-of-way over upbound on Great Lakes, Western Rivers, specified waters; proposes passage (9, 14)
Crossing a river	Normal crossing rule	Power-driven vessel crossing a river keeps out of the way of one ascending or descending (Great Lakes / Western Rivers)
Pushing ahead / alongside	Sternlight	**Two towing lights** (yellow) in vertical line instead; Western Rivers: no masthead lights needed
Vessel pushed ahead	Sidelights	Sidelights + **special flashing light** (yellow, 50–70/min) at forward end

Topic	International	Inland
Great Lakes power-driven	—	All-round white may replace 2nd masthead + sternlight
Special anchorage areas	—	< 20 m: no anchor lights, shapes, or sound signals required
Distress	—	Adds high-intensity white light flashing 50–70/min
Law enforcement	—	May show a **flashing blue** light (Annex V)

MEMORY HOOK **"Inland = Intent, International = In-action"**

Inland signals are a conversation (propose, answer). International signals are an announcement (I'm doing it now). And Inland adds **yellow** everywhere: yellow maneuvering light, two yellow towing lights when pushing, yellow special flashing light on the bow of the barge.

TIP **Local to you**

Pickwick Lake, the Tennessee River, and the Mississippi at Memphis are all **Western Rivers / Inland** waters — the downbound-with-current rule, pushing-ahead light rules, and Inland maneuvering signals are what you'll actually see on the water. Watch a tow at night from the riverfront and quiz yourself.

Self-test (answers on next page)

1. (BOTH) At night you see two all-round red lights in a vertical line plus a green sidelight. What is it, and what is it doing?

2. (BOTH) You see red-white-red all-round lights in a vertical line, two masthead lights, and a red sidelight. What is it?

3. (BOTH) In fog you hear one prolonged followed by two short blasts every 2 minutes. List the vessel types that could be sounding it.

4. (INLAND) A vessel meeting you sounds two short blasts. What does it mean and how do you respond if you agree?

5. (INTERNATIONAL) A vessel in sight sounds two short blasts. What does it mean?

6. (BOTH) Two sailing vessels converge; one has the wind on her port side, the other on her starboard side. Which gives way?

7. (BOTH) You are approaching another vessel from 30° abaft her beam. Which rule applies and who keeps clear?

8. (BOTH) In a crossing situation you see the other vessel's green sidelight on your port bow. Are you stand-on or give-way?

9. (BOTH) What is the arc of visibility of a sternlight?

10. (BOTH) Minimum visibility of the masthead light on a 30 m power-driven vessel?

11. (BOTH) A 120 m vessel is anchored in fog. What signals does she sound?

12. (INTERNATIONAL) Three all-round red lights in a vertical line indicate what?

13. (INLAND) Two yellow towing lights in a vertical line at the stern indicate what?

14. (BOTH) In restricted visibility you detect by radar alone a vessel forward of your beam, close quarters developing. What alteration should you avoid?

15. (BOTH) When may the stand-on vessel first take action on her own, and what should she sound?

16. (BOTH) A vessel shows three black balls in a vertical line. What is her status?

17. (BOTH) A sailboat under sail and power shows what day shape?

18. (INLAND) Which distress signal exists only under the Inland Rules?

Answer key

1. NUC, underway and **making way** (sidelights + sternlight added when making way). You're seeing her starboard side.

2. RAM, **underway and making way**, ≥ 50 m (two masthead lights), port side toward you.

3. NUC, RAM, CBD (Intl), sailing, fishing (including at anchor), towing or pushing, and RAM at anchor. (Rule 35)

4. 'I intend to leave you on my **starboard** side' (starboard-to-starboard passing). Agree by answering with **two short**; if in doubt, sound the danger signal.

5. 'I am altering my course to **port**.' No reply is required.

6. The vessel with the wind on her **port** side (port tack). (Rule 12)

7. You're **overtaking** (more than 22.5° abaft her beam) — Rule 13; you keep clear until past and clear, regardless of vessel type.

8. Stand-on. You're seeing her starboard side, so you're on her starboard side; she has you to starboard and must give way.

9. 135° (67.5° either side of dead astern).

10. 5 nautical miles (vessels 20–50 m). It drops to 3 nm only if under 20 m.

11. Rapid ringing of the **bell** forward ~5 s, followed by a **gong** aft ~5 s, at intervals of not more than 1 minute; may add short-prolonged-short. She must also light her decks at night (≥ 100 m).

12. Constrained by draft (Rule 28) — International only.

13. A power-driven vessel **pushing ahead or towing alongside**.

14. An alteration of course to **port** (unless the vessel is being overtaken). Also avoid turning toward a vessel abeam or abaft the beam.

15. As soon as it becomes apparent the give-way vessel is **not taking appropriate action** (Rule 17(a)(ii)); she should sound **at least 5 short** rapid blasts (doubt signal).

16. Aground.

17. A **cone, apex downward** — she's power-driven.

18. A high-intensity **white light flashing 50–70 times per minute**.

TIP Scoring yourself

Aim for 17/18 or better before moving on — the real module requires 90%. Any miss, go back to that page's MEMORY HOOK box and say it out loud three times.